

ONE STEP BACK...

SUSHIL MODI

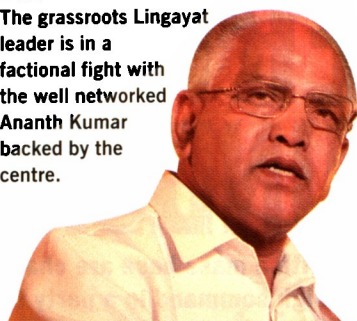
BJP's backward face in Bihar is facing revolt from the upper caste lobby led by state Minister Ashwini Choubey.



RANJAN RAH

B.S. YEDDYURAPPA

The grassroots Lingayat leader is in a factional fight with the well networked Ananth Kumar backed by the centre.



PH. RAJASHEKAR

KALYAN SINGH

The OBC leader won UP for BJP in 1991. Known as Hindu hriday samrat he got into a turf war with Rajnath Singh. Now a marginalised figure.

"Some people have turned the party into a kitchen cabinet and are treating it like their fiefdom. Democratic ways have become extinct."

which prefers his English-speaking Brahmin rival Ananth Kumar. Ever since 1999 the Yeddyurappa camp has been asking BJP to name him the chief ministerial candidate while Kumar has been advocating the principle of "collective leadership". Now, sensing victory, the central leadership has decided to project Yeddyurappa as its chief minister. Not only does he have the support of the powerful Lingayat community, he also has the sympathy card working for him. However, it does not mean that Kumar is out of the reckoning. Recently appointed secretary of the election management committee and a member of the central election committee, he continues to play a key role.

These states are symptomatic of a larger churning within BJP where grassroots leaders with a mass base are facing opposition from an armchair central leadership. Munde's clash was with state President Nitin Gadkari who is said to have the tacit support of the central leadership. After his brother-in-law Mahajan's death Munde has been marginalised in state politics. Between them the Mahajan-Munde duo had worked out a formidable Brahmin-obc combination in Maharashtra. Since then the link has been broken.

Before leaving for Delhi, Munde had said in Aurangabad, "Some people have turned the party into a kitchen cabinet and are treating it like their personal fiefdom. Democratic ways have become extinct." Both Advani and Rajnath have surrounded themselves with yes men with little understanding

of mass politics. While Advani's team has a savvy, English-speaking drawing room appeal, Rajnath's natural inclination is towards the band of Sangh leaders deputed for party work. It would be difficult to find a grassroots leader in either of the teams.

The party stereotype seems to be intact. Known traditionally as the party of Banias and Brahmins, BJP tends to favour the aspirations of its urban centric upper-caste base. Says a party functionary from Uttar Pradesh, "If you are a Brahmin, Vaishya or Thakur you always have the upper hand. Leaders of the rest of the communities are part of 'adjustment', not of the 'establishment'." Mass-leaders like Kalyan Singh, who won a state for BJP for the first time in 1991, and Vinay Katiyar, who was instrumental in giving the state unit a new identity in the 1990s, are nowhere to be seen now. They may have been accommodated at the headquarters on Ashoka Road in Delhi but that is just part of the "adjustment" plan. Kalyan has not been given any major responsibility and, instead, has been blamed for the poor show in Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections last year. Munde too was brought to the centre as general secretary in charge of Rajasthan, to make life more comfortable for Gadkari.

The emergence of backward leaders like Kalyan, Katiyar, Narendra

Modi, and Uma Bharati was the result of a social engineering formula crafted by former party ideologue K.N. Govindacharya. For a while the idea of breaking the high-caste barrier had been playing on the leadership's imagination. Today, Narendra Modi is the only one who retains his clout and he has never played the caste card. Bharati blames the male-dominated Delhi lead-

SIPRA DAS



TALKING HEADS: Sushma Swaraj, Advani, Rajnath, Naidu and Ananth at an election committee meeting